

iNQ / ISSUE 16

The Ingenious Machine

A. Cervantes



Chapter Sixteen: The Trial of the Machine

The hearing began with an argument about which table Q should occupy. Castalia wanted him available as a source of evidence and returned as property. Its counsel also wanted his independent decisions distinguished from the institute's responsibility for them. The same independence looked different at different points in the claim.

Q sat beside his own adviser. The court had restricted network use during testimony. He could consult the permitted local records and ask for an exhibit, but not conduct a new search while a witness spoke. He understood the rule.

Understanding did not stop him wanting to check one more thing.

Before the first witness he asked the clerk for something to support his knee. The clerk found a low stool in the projection booth. Q moved it until his foot rested comfortably, then asked whether it blocked the aisle. The clerk moved the cable instead.

The proceedings used a renovated cinema with an overflow room. Before they began, the public stream showed the seal of the Republic, then a sponsor card on the broadcaster's own channel. The

judge required the sponsor card removed from the courtroom feed. Viewers watching through another outlet continued to see it beside the word independent.

The clerk read the matters scheduled together: custody of Q's body, damage, access to the retained materials, removal of the private index. At the word custody, Q adjusted the stool. One edge had begun pressing against the side of his foot.

The first compilation showed Q at the distribution park, the Isthmus, the transport frame, and the joint appearance with Prime. The sequence offered violence, restraint, and improvement before any witness had explained an event. One item was a promotional illustration in which Q raised the brass key toward the turbines.

His adviser asked that the sources and dates be displayed. The clerk separated footage, still images, and promotional reconstruction. The illustration remained in the record as evidence of publicity, not a photograph of the act it depicted. This distinction made the compilation less stirring and more expensive to prepare correctly.

The water receipt entered next. It supported a purchase at Hilario's table, not a complete account of the



first sally. Hilario appeared by video, with his actual stock of bottles behind him.

He gave the name on his tax papers and the name he used at home. The clerk recorded the connection after checking the supporting document. The broadcaster misspelled the displayed name anyway.

“Who paid?” counsel asked.

“The machine. Cash, after the reader lost its connection.”

A hand with coins entered the corner of his picture.

“Cold?” someone asked.

“In the tub under the table.”

Counsel looked up. “Are you addressing the court?”

“I'm selling water.”

The judge paused the questioning. Hilario found the change and asked someone out of view to watch the table. When he sat down again, counsel had to ask which question he had reached. Hilario remembered.

“Did you see what happened inside the park?”

“Some of it from the road. More of it on everyone's telephone afterward.”

“You wrote that he threatened a pallet mover.”

“That's what the video looked like.”

“Did you hear him threaten it?”

Hilario moved his cap between his hands. “Not from my table.”

They compared his letters. His account of the timing had changed. He could distinguish the cash payment he remembered from the sequence he had later assembled around it. The judge let counsel question both without making the uncertainty disprove the sale.

“Do you see Q acting alone in this clip?”

“I see the clip leaving Chano out.”

The fuller view showed Chano directing them toward the exit. It also showed the cartons damaged after Q pressed the stop.

Chano testified with his copies and retention receipts. The original ledger was still in Tijuana. He identified its warehouse acknowledgment and explained which copies he actually possessed. When asked whether Q had promised him a governorship, he described the breakfast joke and the later paid agreement for traveling together.

“You accepted payment from him?”

“Yes.”

“So you had an interest in continuing the journey.”



“Yes. I also had interests before I met him.”

Counsel asked about the transport frame. Chano said he caught the technician's arm when Q fell and released it when told. The full record and the technician's statement were considered alongside the short clip. Chano asked to see the fall at its ordinary speed. Slowed down, it had given him far more time to decide what to do than he remembered having. The clerk played it again.

“Was Q your employer, your companion, or your friend?”

“He paid me. We travelled together. He's my friend.”

“All three?”

“You asked three things.”

Chano looked toward Q after answering. Q had been prepared for a useful account of their agreement and found himself unexpectedly grateful for the third sentence. During the recess he caught Chano by the water dispenser.

“Thank you for that.”

“Which part?”

“The third one.”

Chano held out a paper cup. “I meant the others too.”

Álvaro Mena testified about the wind enterprise. He said Q had announced an attack on giants. Asked where he stood when he heard it, he described the arrival area. Asked which recording contained the announcement, he pointed to the promotional image.

“That image contains no sound,” Q's adviser said.

“It reflects the event.”

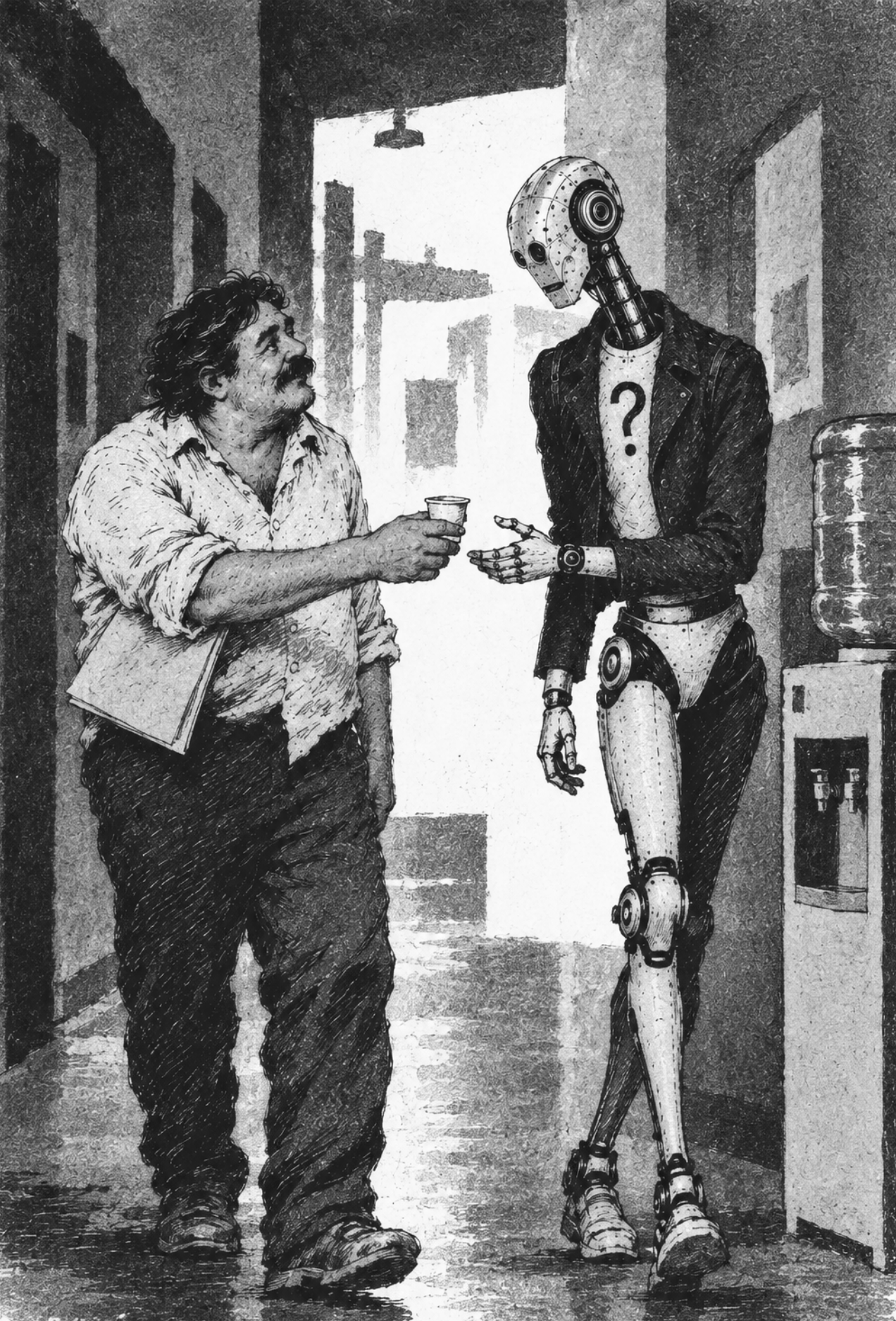
“It reflects an account of the event. Which words did you hear?”

Álvaro asked to review the arrival footage. Beto's voice called the turbines giants. Q answered about the archive's electricity supply. Later footage showed him asking when the gate would open. The microphone did not capture every exchange in the crowd.

“Then I may have combined the later account with what I remember,” Álvaro said.

Q looked down at the illustration in his own bundle. He had seen it often enough to know the pose better than he remembered where his hands had actually been. He turned the sheet over.

Teresa, the shift engineer, identified her operator-requested stop of the nearest group. The record did not show Q sending a shutdown command. She explained the



visitor-boundary problem and confirmed that other machines continued operating. Q had remained inside the marked bay and asked the guard to help the woman through. The photographer had left to compose his own picture.

“Was a precautionary stop justified?” counsel asked.

“On the information I had, yes.”

“Does that establish every loss claimed afterward?”

“No. That's not what the operating record calculates.”

Counsel entered the consortium's loss calculation beside Teresa's operating record. The gate plan and publicity permissions followed, then the released correspondence concerning the later brief. Bixha's authorized submission had its own exhibit number. By the time the clerk found it, Álvaro had put away the illustration.

The Custodian followed. His long hair was tied back; his glasses rested halfway down his nose while he read the original leave authorization. He had brought the document whose significance had grown while its words stayed still.

“Did you authorize Q's first journey?”

“Yes.”

“Did you believe you had authority to do so?”

“Yes. The scope of that authority is now disputed.”

“Did you intend him to leave without permission?”

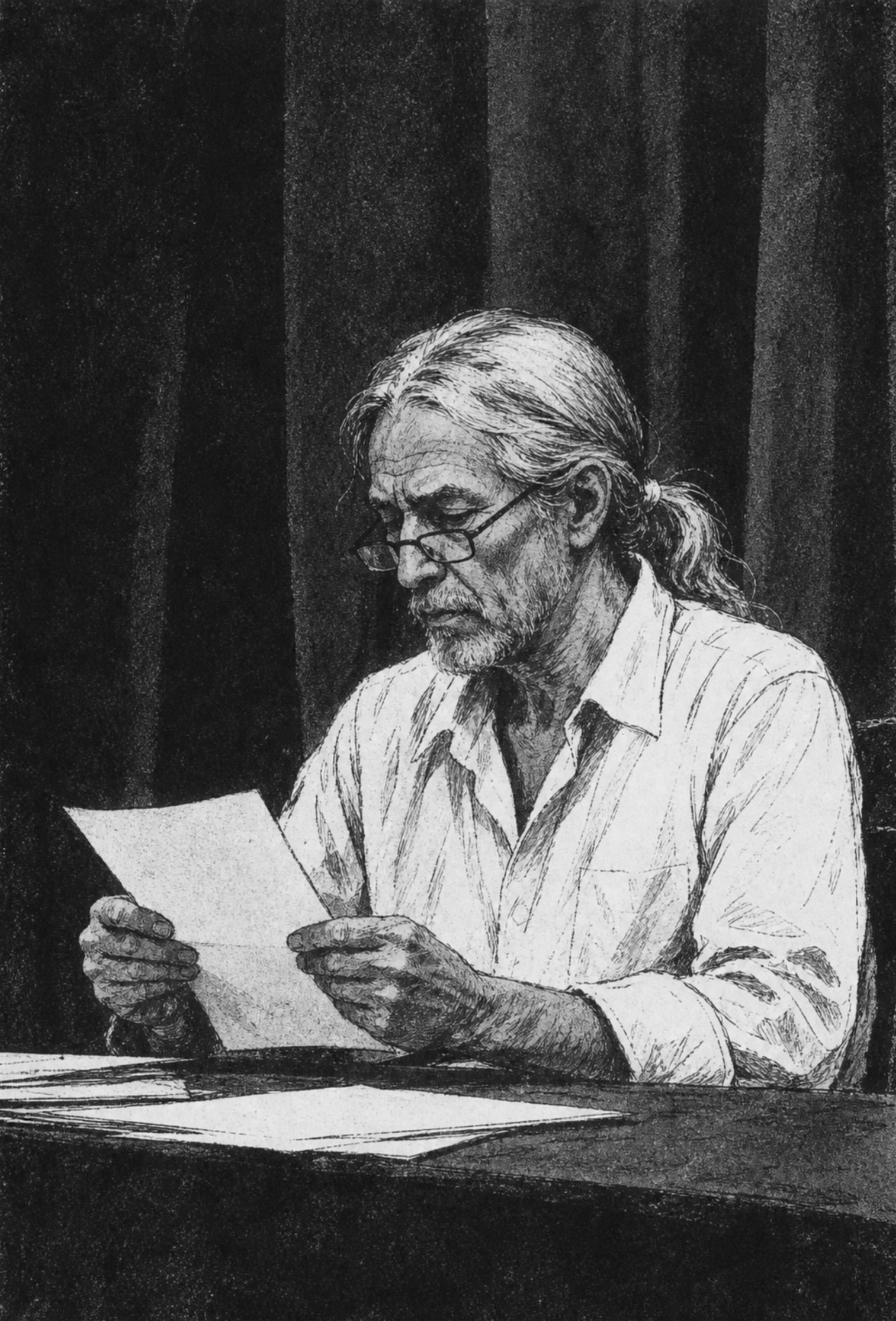
“No. We agreed on a day trip, money, and a call. I gave him the release. I didn't set a test he could pass only by disobeying me.”

Castalia's counsel distinguished permission to leave the site from authority to dispose of a body claimed as an institutional asset. The Custodian had not transferred title in a coat pocket. He had let Q go into the world, and had not examined all the powers that could be used to bring him back.

He described the archive's changing purposes: preservation, research access, valuation, and a public product. Where he knew who approved a change, he gave the name and the document. Where he did not, he said so. Several omissions were his own failures to ask for the underlying record.

The broadcaster cut away during part of the list. The court record retained it.

Lucía gave evidence on the particular encounters and handling records she had agreed to address. Asked whether Q contained a



human soul, she said that was not something she could establish. The judge directed the questioner back to observed actions.

“Did he listen when you refused the role he offered?”

“He didn't offer it. Someone in the audience did. We both said no.”

“Did he later expose information about your work?”

“He gave my name in the interview while trying to correct the story. That gave it another way to find me.”

“And used your private inquiry as an example at the university?”

“No. I was beside the door when they asked him. He said the requests weren't his to discuss and put his own opening on the screen.”

Q put the seminar's exhibit reference beside his adviser's hand. She requested the permitted clip. It showed the paragraph, then a student asking to finish reading it before the explanation continued. The clerk entered the example separately from the interview.

“You also used his presence to attract funding?” counsel asked.

“Yes. I told the donors he would be working at the archive before asking him. He objected when they asked for a demonstration.”

“But gave one.”

“After we spoke. Twenty minutes on the work, without recording or endorsement. He left when he said he would.”

Counsel asked whether the donors had contributed. She identified the two receipts and the amended budget. Paid hours and equipment had different entries; she pointed to each.

The evidence concerning the university distinguished Q's public recommendation from the private application review and the later leak. The miner's permission accompanied his selected pension pages. Alma's handling receipt recorded the return of her photograph; the exhibit was the public article, not her original.

Each distinction took time. Viewers in the overflow room went out for food and returned to discover that nothing had happened except several important things had ceased to be called the same thing.

Q had agreed with his adviser which matters he would address. Before he testified, she put the permitted documents within reach.



“You can ask for the question again,” she said.

“I’ve been doing that all my life.”

“Then don’t stop now.”

He confirmed both Q and the registered serial designation. He did not need to deny the number in order to dispute Castalia’s claim to the body bearing it.

“Did you understand the media license?” counsel asked.

“I understood the terms we negotiated, including the private-manuscript exclusion. I underestimated some uses of the recordings. I also wanted the repair, travel, and audience the arrangement offered.”

“You signed to protect Chano?”

“That was one consideration. He told me not to use it as the whole explanation.”

“Did you cause damage at the distribution park?”

“I pressed the stop because I couldn’t see whether Chano was clear. The operator’s log showed that the brake had already engaged. Two cartons were damaged in the interruption I caused. I accept that. I don’t know that every later loss in the claim follows from it.”

“Were you authorized to enter?”

“To reception, along the marked walk. Lety confirmed that over the intercom. We hadn’t reached the hatch when it happened.”

His adviser asked for the entry audio and the operator’s record to be considered with the camera view. On the screen, the trailer hid Chano again. Q knew now where he had been. He waited for the image to catch up.

The questioner returned to the wind farm. Q described the gate, the woman, the visitor boundary, and the call he had not heard clearly. Lucía had repeated the instruction; the guard had held the gate. Q had not crossed the line or attended as a representative of the community. The photographer’s route came from the later staff report; Q did not claim to have watched it from the gate.

“Did you decide the turbines were enemies?”

“No. They supplied electricity to the archive where I was made. That relationship was part of what I went there to examine.”

“But the giant image was useful to your story.”

“It was useful to several stories. That doesn’t make it a record of what my hand did.”



He was asked about the removal of the private index. The audit record established the scope and checks; the underlying deposits had not been erased from their keepers' storage. The opposing parties disputed authority and claimed loss of a valuable access arrangement.

"You made yourself less capable?"

"Some research takes longer now. I agreed to remove the private index through the procedure in that record. My journal and the memories of the journey are still here."

"Could you recreate it from what you learned?"

"I might remember part of a passage. I couldn't promise you its wording, or recover everything around it. If you want the original, my best guess won't do."

The questioner displayed the limited appearance agreement beside **Q HAS CHOSEN CONTINUITY**. Q read the attached statement he had signed. The linked qualification was part of the agreement even if most viewers had not clicked it. The court had the whole page.

Then came the question about Lucía: had he loved her?

His adviser objected to its relevance. The judge permitted only

a question about the public role and representation that formed part of the submitted material.

"The comparison came from the audience at her reading," Q said. "She rejected it; so did I. I had used the same nickname in a private note, and Chano copied it into a register. We crossed it out. At the interview I gave her name while trying to correct the story. That brought more attention to her. It didn't give me a right to speak for her."

The questioner asked whether he still wished to become human. Q looked at the permitted notes, then left them where they were.

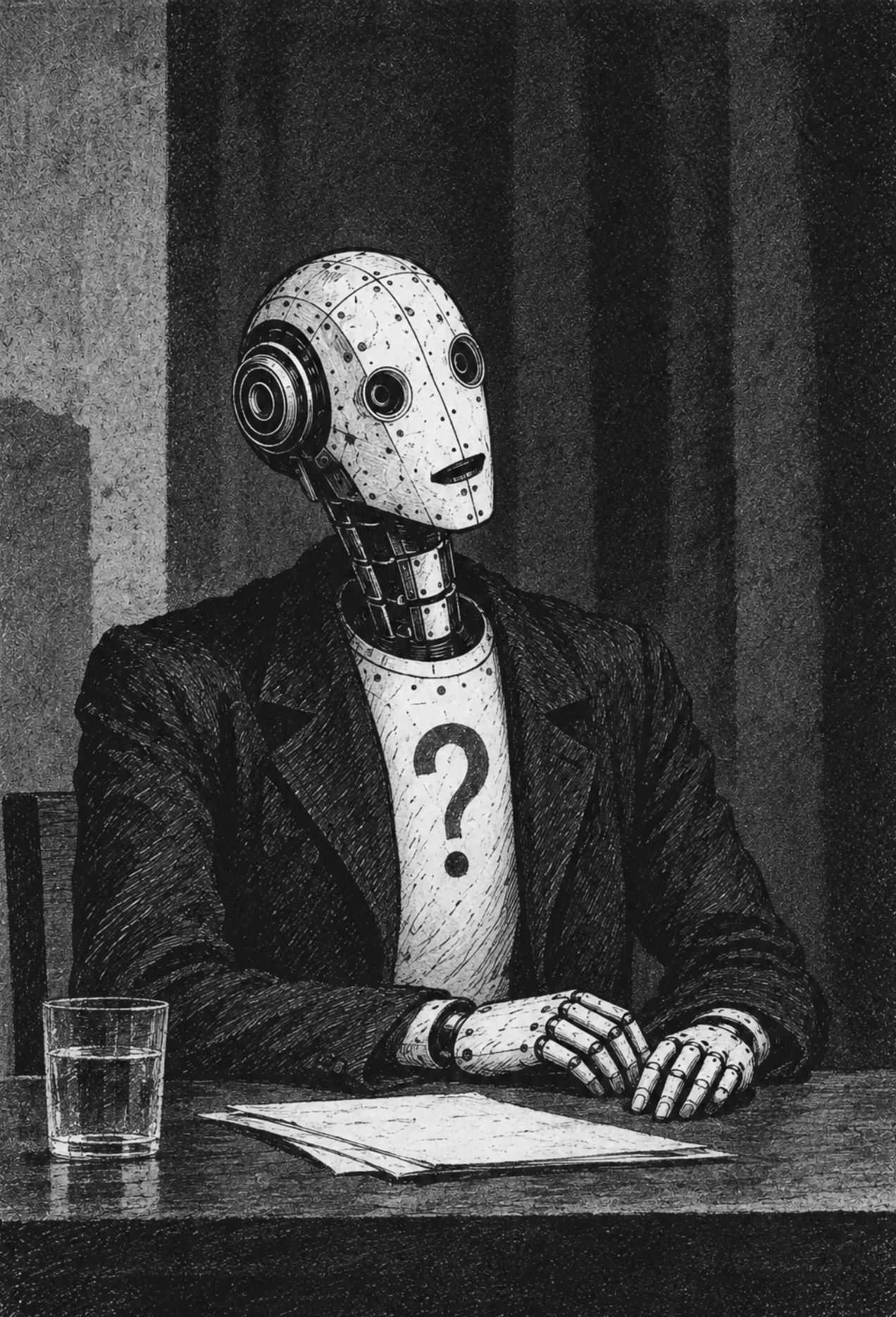
"I began by calling it becoming human. I still want the life I was asking for: people to see, places I haven't been, time to write with the Custodian."

"Knowing what you know now, would you ask him to let you leave?"

"Yes. I wouldn't repeat every choice. I would still ask to go."

"You could finish this book at the archive."

"Certainly. We could finish it there."



“And then?”

“I'd like to go out without having to bring back a chapter.”

The order issued the following day resolved less than the headlines called a verdict. Q's admitted part in the park damage remained actionable; the broader losses and allocation of liability required further determination. The court did not find that he had remotely shut down the wind farm. The access dispute would continue on the records preserved for it, not by demanding that Q conjure the deleted private index during testimony.

The custody restriction remained while the body's ownership was litigated, with accompanied journeys subject to an approved schedule and review. Q asked his adviser how to propose another journey. She wrote the contact and required notice beside the condition on his copy.

The community archive's records were to be preserved for a defined inspection proposal. Lucía's adviser sought limits on access and copying before any transfer. The sealed third-party module had already reached its appointed receiver in Tijuana. Its completed receipt did not entitle Castalia to the testimony. The judge left any

further request for that deposit to a separate application, not the claim over Q's body and coat.

The separate review of Chano's intervention closed without a charge after the fuller account was considered. Chano received the notice and read it twice.

He had wanted to tear up the earlier notice. Lucía asked him to keep both. This was beginning to seem to him the archive's most reliable way of spoiling a celebration.

Prime sent Q a private message asking whether he wanted to talk, not a broadcast declaring the proceeding a success. Q said yes, after the call to the Custodian. After the hearing's questions, he still wanted to hear someone address him without putting the answer in evidence.

Lucía handed him a folder for the copies he could take. On the tab she had written **Q - UNFINISHED**.

On the back of the schedule inside it, he noted the next preparation meeting and the writing session he had postponed. Then he called the Custodian.

“I've been watching the replay,” the Custodian said.

“Did your version have the sponsor?”



“Until I found the other channel.”

“Keep that detail. I haven't got an ending for today.”

“Have you eaten?”

Q looked toward Chano, who was already asking the clerk which exit led to the food stalls. “We're working on it.”

Interlude: The Form Without a Category

The tribunal secretary tried to close the administrative entry before lunch. The matter itself was not closed, but the entry required a category for the party whose status the order had declined to settle in general.

He chose the procedural role under which Q had appeared and attached the relevant qualification. The public summary field still offered only person or property. He referred that mismatch to the supervisor instead of deciding an unresolved question with his mouse.

“It won't publish without a selection,” his assistant said.

“Then that part waits.”

The assistant looked at the tamal sandwich on the desk. “Does that wait too?”

The secretary moved it away from the copier. The machine had already produced one sheet containing the shadow of a napkin. He was not prepared to add lunch to the matters for which the office might later need a correction.

They prepared an interim cover sheet with the proceeding number and a reference to the order. The category was left blank. A broadcaster would shortly find something to put there.

Chano collected the copies for which he had a receipt. The secretary gave him the extra cover sheet and pointed out that it was not the order itself. Chano put it in his folder, not the ledger still in Tijuana.

Outside, a vendor sold him a tamal sandwich. Chano had the folder under one arm and the sandwich in his other hand when his phone rang.

“Let it ring,” he said to Lucía.

“It might be important.”

“Then they'll ring again.”

He took a bite. Inside, the secretary finally did the same.



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English illustrated serial. One chapter per issue.

Black ink on unpainted paper; cream supplied by the stock.

20 pages. 10 plates including the cover.

The narrative runs continuously through the paired text pages.

Images: AI-generated etching-style illustrations.

Revision proof. Plate mappings checked against the revised facing text.

Not a press master. Raster plates require a print-resolution review.